San Marino, Dooradoyle Road: does it work?

Tags: COUNCIL pre-planning record ref 1044365, 7 Nov 2025. ARCH Reddy A+U proposal (20 Oct 2025) and presentation (17 Sept 2025). TRACKER planning action tracker, 20 Oct 2025. **You say there is a consensus that the location is not suitable. None of the documents says so; the points below test that view.**

1. The site

Council record: "approx. size 1,030 sqm" (it does not say whether that is the site or the proposed floor area; the contribution is charged per sqm of floor area, so it is probably the building); an existing single-storey dwelling to be demolished; a support centre with about 8 therapy rooms, welcome lounge, group room and garden. Zoned existing residential, where health centres are generally permitted. MWCF is recorded as "landowner" at the council meeting. COUNCIL ARCH

1a. Your understanding, not in the documents

- The site and property are **too small** for what the Foundation needs.
- **No planning application has been lodged** (the tracker and proposal are consistent with this: pre-planning only).
- It was **bought for more than 400,000 euro** (your understanding; no price in the folder), **funded with the support of the JP McManus Family Charity Foundation** (your account; not stated in the documents). Funder conditions may apply to the use or sale of the property.
- **Funder position (John Lawler spoke to Helen O'Donnell of the McManus Foundation, per John; verbal, not in writing):** the Foundation will agree to San Marino being sold **if a more suitable property is identified and there is a plan to make it suitable, by lease or purchase**. So the order is: find and plan the replacement first, then sell.

2. Points that make it unsuitable

Issue	What the documents say
No parking on site	The layout has no parking in the site, only set-down. The council, with the Acting Senior Planner, shares concerns and says off-site parking "could not be enforced"; some parking must be inside the red line. COUNCIL
Off-site parking is not secured	A shopping centre needs approval from owners based in Dublin; a rugby club would give a letter for 20 weekday spaces. TRACKER
Vehicle access	Pedestrian and cycle access only from Dooradoyle Road; vehicles possibly from the south through Birch Grove, an estate taken in charge by the council, subject to sightlines and consent. COUNCIL
Fitting a bigger building	The council suggests a part two-storey design to free space for parking, with impact on the neighbour to the north (high-level opaque windows, visual impact and daylight checks). COUNCIL
Time	Planning about 8 weeks after design sign-off plus 12 weeks for permission; detailed design and tender 6 to 8 months; construction about 15 months. Uisce Éireann feasibility has a 16 week lead time. ARCH TRACKER
Cost exposure	Development contribution of 40 euro a sqm (about 41,000 euro if 1,030 sqm is the floor area, Cuan's arithmetic) unless MWCF is a voluntary, not-for-profit applicant. No construction budget in the folder. COUNCIL

3. Points in its favour

- **Location:** 3 minutes by car, 8 by bus, 13 on foot and 4 by bike from University Hospital Limerick. ARCH
- **Principle accepted:** the council considers it acceptable in principle on the zoning. COUNCIL
- **Progress made:** pre-planning held, topographical and building surveys done, design options drawn, and the architect is pro bono to planning stage. ARCH

4. What is not in the folder (ask tomorrow)

- The purchase price or valuation, who owns the site, and whether it is bought or only under offer.
- Why the consensus is "not suitable": your understanding is size; confirm, and whether parking and access are also reasons.
- If MWCF sells San Marino: with **no application lodged**, the 35% sale-with-permission fee does not apply. But the architect's terms say that if the site is sold **before lodgement they are entitled to the portion of the full fee to planning that reflects the work**

completed, even though they described the work as pro bono. Ask the architect to confirm in writing what, if anything, would be due on a sale.

- What was paid, how much was the McManus support and on what terms (grant, loan or conditions on use, sale or proceeds), any charge on the property, and what an agent says it is worth now.
- The McManus agreement in writing: what "more suitable" and "a plan" must include, whether it covers proceeds as well as the sale, and who signs off the plan.
- Whether the AF1 safety notification has been lodged (the architect says "now").
- Whether the "Dooradoyle council offices" idea the Chairman raised on 24 Oct is a different site; I cannot tell.

5. Questions to ask

- "What is the one deciding reason we're dropping San Marino, and what would have to change for it to work?"
- "What did we pay, what conditions came with the McManus support, and what is it worth if sold today? Do we need the funder's agreement before we sell or change use?"
- "What do we need in an interim location, and by when, given a build of 15 months or more?"

Limits: I have not seen a price (over 400,000 euro is your understanding), title, valuation or budget, and the map from Máiréad has not arrived. The council record is the only independent source; the rest are the architect's or the Foundation's own statements.